

The Global Burden of Mental Illness

Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

Hundreds of Millions Affected

Lifetime risk of major depression

1 in 3

WOMEN

will experience major depression
in their lifetime

1 in 5

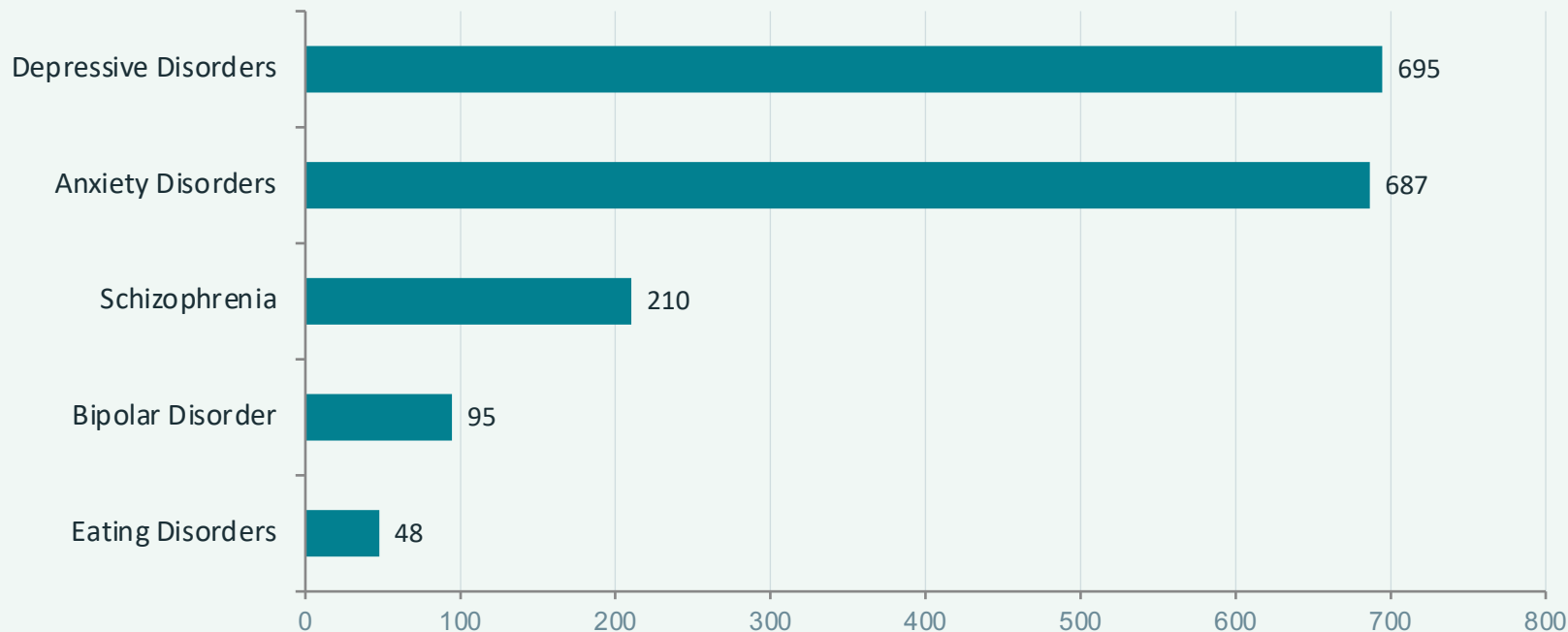
MEN

will experience major depression
in their lifetime

Mental health conditions range from common disorders like depression and anxiety to less common but severe conditions such as schizophrenia and bipolar disorder. All carry significant individual and societal costs.

Disease Burden by Mental Illness Category

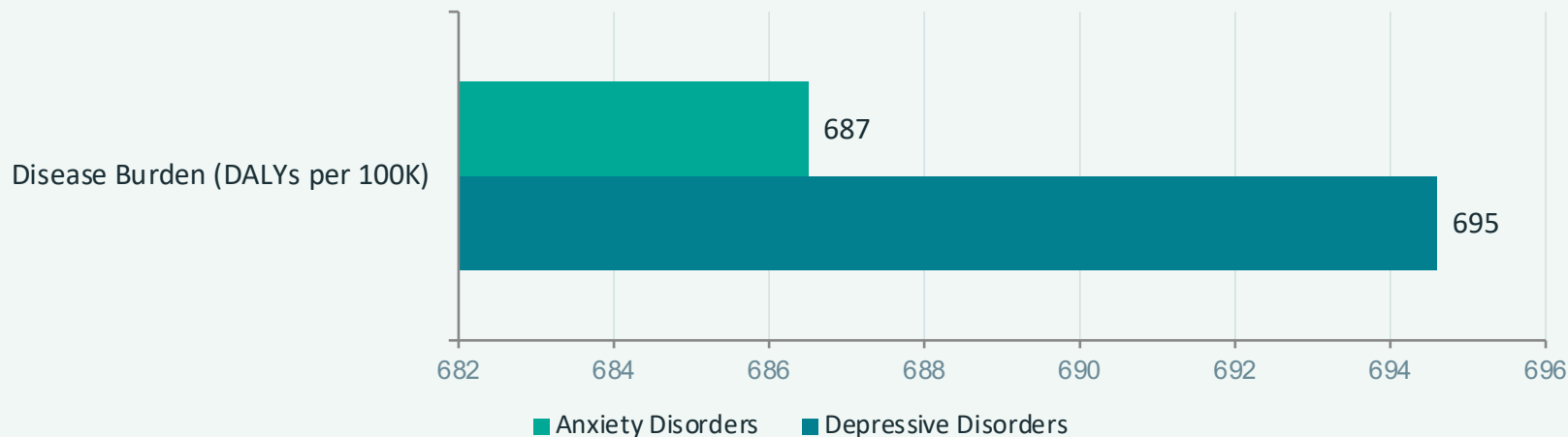
DALYs per 100,000 people | World, 2023



Source: IHME, Global Burden of Disease (2025) via Our World in Data

Depression and Anxiety: Nearly Equal Burden

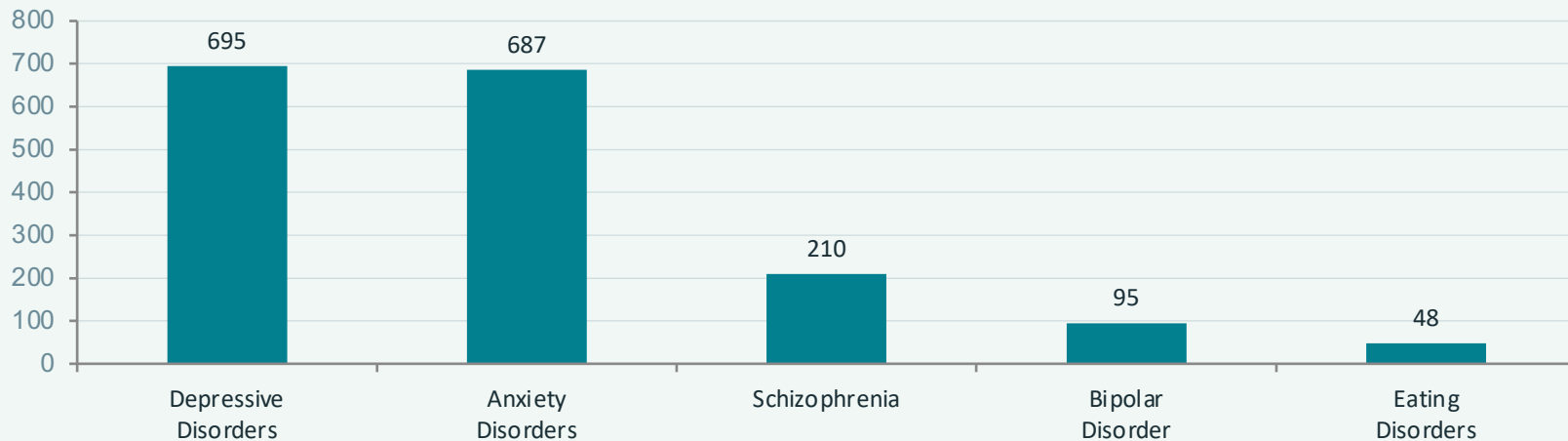
Together they account for roughly 80% of the total mental health disease burden



Combined, depressive and anxiety disorders generate ~1,381 DALYs per 100,000 — dwarfing schizophrenia, bipolar disorder, and eating disorders combined (352 DALYs per 100K).

Lower Prevalence, Severe Individual Impact

Schizophrenia and Bipolar Disorder vs. Common Disorders



Schizophrenia: 210.2 DALYs

Affects fewer people, but causes severe disability — reflecting the intense individual burden.

Bipolar Disorder: 94.6 DALYs

A smaller population burden, yet meaningful — individuals face recurrent and disruptive episodes.

The Treatment Gap

Mental illnesses are treatable — yet many people do not receive adequate care



Stigma

Many people are uncomfortable disclosing symptoms to healthcare professionals or even people they know.



Access

Treatment is often lacking, especially in low- and middle-income countries.



Quality

Even where treatment exists, it may be of poor quality and insufficient to meet patient needs.



Underreporting

Discomfort with disclosure makes it difficult to estimate true prevalence — the actual burden may be higher than reported.

Good data is essential to understand these conditions — how, when, and why they occur, and how they can be treated effectively.

How People Cope with Mental Health Conditions

Global survey data reveals wide variation across countries and cultures



Prescribed Medication

Common in higher-income settings where pharmaceutical access and healthcare infrastructure are established.



Religious or Spiritual Activities

Prevalent in many regions worldwide, reflecting deep cultural and communal support frameworks.



Talking to Friends or Family

A widely reported coping mechanism across diverse demographics and income levels.

Policy interventions must account for cultural, economic, and healthcare system differences — not apply a one-size-fits-all approach.

Key Takeaways

Priorities for Policy Analysts and Program Planners

- 1 Depression and anxiety together represent the overwhelming majority of mental health DALYs — roughly 80% of the combined burden across five categories.
- 2 Schizophrenia and bipolar disorder carry disproportionate individual burden despite lower population-level prevalence.
- 3 Effective treatments exist but access and quality remain inadequate, particularly in low- and middle-income countries.
- 4 Stigma suppresses both help-seeking and accurate data, meaning the true burden of mental illness is likely underestimated.
- 5 Policy should prioritize scaling evidence-based interventions for common disorders while maintaining specialized care for severe conditions.